

5.4.1 Area of Study 1 - Exploiting the Resource

Starting Point

The way the candidate's chosen instrument (or voice) produces and exploits its sound:

- its range/compass;
- its characteristic timbre/colour;
- its technical strengths and limitations;
- idiomatic performing techniques;
- enhancement using ICT (where appropriate);
- its place in its 'family' (e.g. trumpet in relation to cornet, or as the highest instrument in an orchestral brass group, bass guitar in relation to other electric guitars and acoustic guitar).

Core

Candidates should develop an understanding of how their instrument (or voice) is used in a selected genre, through the study of three pieces, at least one of which must be performed by the candidate. This study should enable candidates to recognise similarities and differences in the way in which their instrument is exploited in relation to:

- the contextual background of the pieces studied;

- the use of different instrument-specific techniques;
- either: the roles of performers in a relevant ensemble and the contribution of the selected instrument
or: ways in which the instrument may be self-sufficient as an unaccompanied soloist;
- ways in which music is created/recreated and the contributions of different composers, conductors/leaders or performers;
- the way the music is notated and the different ways notations are interpreted by performers (e.g. Baroque ornamentation, rhythmic flexibility in jazz idioms, different ways of performing from chord symbols on keyboards);
- changing social expectations and the influence (where appropriate) of new technology.

It is important that the genre be identified in a way that offers scope for suitable depth of study e.g. solo music for the instrument across a range of historical periods, a specific type of pop, music for keyboards, songs from musicals, or solo studies which explore aspects of technique. Three pieces should be selected which will enable comparisons to be drawn and which will support understanding of similarities and differences in pieces within the genre.

Links

Area of Study 2: candidates whose instrument usually fulfils a predominantly melodic role should be encouraged to examine the melodic nature of the selected pieces to support their understanding of *Techniques of Melodic Composition*. In a similar way, performers on chordal or percussive instruments (or predominantly bass instruments such as tuba) might focus on the ways in which their instrument provides a harmonic or rhythmic support to melodies. In the Terminal Task (4.3.1) candidates will have the option either to communicate their melodic response to a given stimulus by performing it on their own instrument (or using ICT) or to submit it in written form.

Areas of Study 3 and 4: candidates will have the opportunity to compare how instruments other than their own are exploited by composers and performers in their study of *Dance Music* and *Traditions and Innovation*. They will also be able to draw on their understanding of their own instrument in their composition of a piece in one of the styles defined by these two areas.

Language for Learning

Candidates should be taught to understand, recognise aurally, and correctly use the following terminology which describes features which arise specifically within the content of this Area of Study:

Range, compass, timbre, articulation and words associated with techniques specific to the instrument (e.g. arco, double-tonguing, rim shot, fill).

The names of the composers of the music studied should also be known.